

Saying times and making appointments

Learner workbook

Agree on an unambiguous time.

Understand the distinction

You can say 9:15 as nine fifteen or a quarter past nine. 9:45 can be nine forty-five or a quarter to ten. Digital forms are often easiest when confirming an appointment.

Use a.m. or p.m. when the part of the day is unclear. Noon is midday; midnight is the start of a new day in date-based schedules. Include the date and time zone for an international meeting. Confirm rather than guess.

Compare the patterns

PAST THE HOUR

a quarter past nine

9:15

BEFORE THE HOUR

a quarter to ten

9:45

CONFIRM

Is that 9 a.m. Tokyo time?

Clarify the time zone and part of day.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. Write half past two in numbers.

2. Write a quarter to six in numbers.

3. What should you clarify in Let's meet at eight if you are in different countries?

Use it in your own life

Write an appointment and a question confirming its time zone.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. 2:30

Half past means thirty minutes after the hour.

2. 5:45

It is fifteen minutes before six.

3. The date, a.m. or p.m., and time zone.

A complete appointment avoids assumptions.

One possible response

Let's meet on 12 September at 10 a.m. Is that London time?

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-31.html